Sowarigpa at a Glance

About Sowa-Rigpa

"Sowa-Rigpa" is one of the oldest, well documented and currently practised medical traditions of the world. It has been in popular practice in Tibet, Mongolia, Bhutan, some parts of China, Nepal, Himalayan regions of India and few parts of former Soviet Union, etc. In India, it is popular in Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Darjeeling and now in Tibetan settlements all over India. Believed to have originated from Bhagwan Buddha 2500 years ago in India, Sowa-Rigpa is based on theories of hByung-Ba-lNga (Panch Mahabhuta /five elements) and Nyes-Pa-gSum (Tri-dosh/ three humours). According to hByung-Ba-lNga theory, all the animate and inanimate phenomena of this universe are composed of five elements. It is on the theory of five basic elements that the science of physiology, pathology and pharmacology are established. Due to its strong socio-cultural background and holistic approach of balancing body, mind and environment, this medical system can provide healthy solutions for many mental and physical problems of the modern age. Sowa-Rigpa is based on a systematic and logical framework of understanding the body, disease and its relationship with the environment. The diagnostic techniques and composition of medicine, etc., are based on the creativity, immensity, delicacy and compassion of the medical practitioner. Sowa-Rigpa as a philosophy follows the key Buddhist tenets of self-sacrifice, karma and ethics with a holistic approach using body and mind to observe a healthy way of life, in complete harmony with nature.

Sowa-Rigpa is popularly known as Amchi medicine in most part of Indian Himalayas. Derived from the Mangolian word of “Aem-rJe” meaning superior to all; the practitioners of this medicine are known as Amchis. Till early 1960s, Amchi medicine used to be the only healthcare facility for the people of these regions and still is an essential means of healthcare alternative among the Himalayan Buddhist society due to the strong socio-cultural linkage. Amchis are not only socially revered but also spiritually respected as the representatives of Sangs-rGyas-sMan-bLa (Medicine Buddha). It takes several years to become a skillful Amchi, which requires hard theoretical and practical training. In most of Himalayan regions Amchis, are trained through rGyud-Pa (lineage) system in families, where knowledge is passed down from father to son through generations. Now however, education in Amchi medicine can be obtained formally with professional training.





Principles of Sowa-Rigpa

Philosophical Background

The fundamental text book rGyud-bZhi(Four Tantras) of Sowa-Rigpa is believed to have taught by the Buddha and is therefore closely linked to Buddhist philosophy. Accordingly, it is believed that beings even in their healthy state are'sick' until the attainment of Nirvana and even though disease may not be manifest, it is always present in dormant form until one eliminates the root cause of sickness, namely, 'Ignorance'. Ignorance gives rise to three basic causes of sickness, i.e hDod-Chhags (desire/lust) root cause of rlung (Vata, wind energy), Zhe-sDang (anger) root cause of mkhris-Pa (Pitta, Bile/heat energy) and gTi-Mug (mental darkness) root cause of Bad-Kan (Kapha, Phlegm/cool energy). All animate and inanimate phenomena of the universe are composed of same material based on hByung-Ba-lNga(five elements) interdependent on the Karma of all the living beings. The behaviour and conduct of physician and patient are also largely based on Buddhist principles. The Buddhist Tantra and Mantra rituals play a very important role in the treatment of patients.

As per the principles of hByung-Ba-lNga and Nyes-Pa-gSum, all phenomenona of this universe are composed of hByung-Ba-lNga; namely Sa, Chhu, Me, rLung and Nam-mkhah (roughly translated as earth, water, fire, wind and space or Dharti, Jal, Agni, Vayu and Akash). The science of physiology, pathology and pharmacology of this system are established on these theories. This means that the human body is composed of these five cosmo-physical elements of hByung-Ba-lNga; and any imbalance in the ratio of these elements in our body results in disorders. The medicine and diet used for the treatment of disorders are also composed of the same five elements. In our body these elements are present in the form of three energies called Nyes-Pa-gSum (three humours), seven physical constituents/ Sapt Dhatucalled Lus-Zungs-bDunand three excretions or Tri-mala called Dri-Ma-gSum. In medicines, dietary products and beverages, they exist in the form of Ro-Drug (six tastes) Nus-Pa-brGyad (eight potencies),Yon-Tan-bChu-bDun (seventeen qualities/properties) and Zhu-rJes-gSum (Three post-digestive tastes). In view of this theory, a physician would use his knowledge, skills and experience in treating a patient by using the theory of similarity and dissimilarity of five elements.

Healthy and Unhealthy Body

A healthy body is typified as a state of balance of three humours (Nyes-Pa-gSum), seven physical constituents (Lus-zungs-bDdun) and three excretions (Dri-Ma-gSum) in

the body with complete harmony of five aggregates (five senses). The three humours are wind (rlung), bile (mkhris-Pa) and phlegm (Bad-Kan) which are further classified into five different kinds for each humour. Seven physical constituents are nutritional essence, blood, muscle tissue, fat tissue, bone tissue, bone marrow and regenerative fluid; the three excretions are stool, urine and sweat. Humours are the biological representative of five elements, physical constituents are the basic tissue elements of the body and excretions are the waste product of the body whose proper elimination is essential for good health. Whether the state of a body is healthy or unhealthy is largely dependent on the balance and imbalance of these twenty-five elements based on proper diet and behavioural patterns. The subject of human body is explained in Sowa-Rigpa in great detail with different chapters on embryology, anatomy, physiology, neurology etc. explained in an appropriate manner with functions of each and every part of the body.

Outline of Disease

Sowa-Rigpa is closely linked with Buddhist philosophy, wherein it is believed that all the breathing creatures on the earth are sick until the root cause, namely ignorance is removed. Due to ignorance three mental poisons anger, desire and mental darkness are born with us – and act as basic origins of illness. When the ratio of three humours wind, bile and phlegm is imbalanced due to circumstantial conditions such as diet, lifestyle, seasonal and mental conditions, it gives rise to different kinds of disorders. Diseases can be classified through different means such as location in the body, type, etc. The presence of 84 thousanddifferent types of afflictive emotions in the mind gives rise to 84 thousand different kinds of diseases. These can be condensed into 1016 kinds, further into 404 kinds, and then into 101 kinds, into three humours and finally into two kinds, namely hot and cold disorders.





Diagnosis

A Sowa-Rigpa doctor employs three main tools for diagnosing a patient i.e. visual diagnosis, diagnosis by touch and diagnosis by questioning. Visual diagnosis comprises of two main methods: (i) tongue examination (ii) analysis of urine.

Various diseases can be diagnosed by checking the nature, colour and smoothness of the tongue. Urine can be analysed at three different stages: fresh urine, while it is cooling down and when it is cold; by looking at its colour, speed of discolouration,

vapour, odour, bubbles, sediments, etc. Diagnosis by touch is represented by the advanced technique of pulse examination followed by touching the body for temperature, smoothness, etc. Pulse is the most important and major diagnostic tool in Sowa-Rigpa, which is explained in thirteen general topics like preparatory conduct, proper time for examination, place, pressure of physician's finger, technique, constitutional pulse, wonderful pulse, general and specific pulse, death pulse, and so on. Questioning is another mode of diagnosing a patient. Here, the history of case, present condition, family background and changes in body are the main questions asked.





Method of Treatment

The methods of treatments have four major sections including diet, behaviour, medicine and accessory/external therapies. Right administration of these four sections is very important for treating a patient in an appropriate manner. Minor ailments can be treated merely with proper regulation of diet and behaviour; a patient with medium disease condition can be treated with medicines such as decoction, powder, pills, purges, emesis, etc.; while patients in advanced stages of disease can be cured by application of accessory/ external therapies like moxa and cauterisation, blood-letting, fomentation, massage, surgery, etc. Buddhist Tantric rituals play a very important role in the treatment of disease. It is a known fact that role of a physician is very important in treatment of a patient; therefore, special emphasis is given on this aspect in this system of medicine.





Pharmacology

Based on the theory of hByung-Ba-lNga, pharmacology of Sowa-Rigpa believes that every substance on the earth has medicinal value and therapeutic efficacy. Medicinal substances are classified into eight major categories i.e. Rin-Po-Chhe (precious metal and stone), Sa-sMan (minerals), rDo-sMan (stones), Shing-sMan (trees), rTsi-sMan (essence and exudates), Thang-sMan(plants) sNgo-sMan (herbs) and Srog-Chhags-

sMan (animal parts). The ingredients of medicine are used in both single and compound forms. Compound medicines are based on permutations and combinations of (i) Ro (taste) based formulations and (ii) Nus-Pa (potency) based formulations. There are about seventeen different categories of medicinal preparations out of which some important preparations are decoction, powder, pills, paste, medicated ghee, medicated ash, medicated wine, extract/resins, medicated bath, etc. The composition of a medicinal preparation is determined on the basis of the six major tastes i.e. sweet, sour, saline, pungent, astringent and bitter. Of these, a composition of sweet taste is dominated by Sa (earth) and Chhu (water) elements; sour taste is dominated by Me (fire) and Sa (earth); saline is dominated by Chhu (water) and Me(fire); bitter is dominated by Chhu (water) and rLung (wind); pungent taste is dominated by Me (fire) and rLung (wind); astringent taste is dominated by Sa (earth) and rLung (wind) element. Sweet, sour, saline and pungent tastes pacify rLung Nyes-Pa (wind humour). Bitter, sweet and astringent tastes pacify Nyes-Pa mkhris-Pa (bile humour). Pungent sour and saline tastes pacify Nyes-Pa Bad-Kan(phlegm humour). Zhu-rJes-gSum, (three post digestive tastes),Nus-Pa-brGyad (eight potencies) and Ngo-Bo (specific action) of particular drugs also play a important role in the choice of drugs. The therapeutic efficacy of drugs is also dependent on the above-mentioned factors.